

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Normalizing the Security Situation of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

Companion to the full research monograph · Data cut-off: 4 October 2026

Normalizing the Security Situation of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa — Conflict Evolution, Threat Dynamics, and Pathways to Sustainable Peace

Data cut-off: 4 October 2026. This summary accompanies a sixteen-chapter research monograph covering the historical evolution, threat landscape, root causes, FATA merger, military operations, policing, deradicalization, geopolitics, socio-economics, governance, civil society, comparative lessons, scenarios and a phased roadmap. Every figure below is attributed in the monograph; contested claims are flagged as contested.

1. The threat has changed shape, not just scale

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa is the principal theatre of a networked insurgency with an interstate rear base — not a residual law-and-order problem. Pakistan ranked first globally in the Global Terrorism Index 2026 (1,139 deaths, 1,045 incidents in 2025), and KP alone recorded 2,331 violence-linked fatalities in 2025, a 44 per cent increase and the highest since 2015 (IEP 2026; CRSS 2025b). The Tehrik-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) umbrella has absorbed more than seventy factions since 2018 (EUAA 2026) and operates across the southern districts and the merged tribal districts while maintaining leadership and logistics in Afghanistan; new front organizations (Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen Pakistan) and the July 2026 split of Jamaat-ul-Ahrar show the coalition is both expanding and fragmenting. Islamic State–Khorasan Province (ISKP) runs a smaller, sectarian-focused campaign, and militant drone warfare has become routine: KP police reported foiling 341 drone attacks in the first half of 2026.

Key indicators at a glance (2025–2026):

Indicator	Value
KP violence-linked fatalities (2025)	2,331 (+44% year-on-year)
National violence-linked fatalities (2025)	3,417 (deadliest since 2015)
KP police killed (H1 2026)	122 (+93.7% year-on-year)
Attacks on police (Jan–Sep 2026)	680 (vs 508 in 2025)
KP districts with recorded terrorism violence (2025)	24 of 40
TTP factions absorbed into the umbrella since 2018	70+
Militant drone attacks foiled in KP (H1 2026)	341
Merged-district fiscal shortfall (by mid-2026)	Rs 568 billion
Tirah Valley families displaced (registered)	33,800+
KP poverty rate (FY2024-25)	35.3%
Estimated annual KP conflict loss	Rs 400–800 billion
Roadmap incremental cost at maturity	Rs 150–250 billion/year

2. The human costs are borne by police and civilians, and they are rising

In the first half of 2026, 122 KP police personnel were killed — a 93.7 per cent increase year-on-year — and 175 were injured; 680 attacks on police were recorded between January and September 2026, against 508 in the comparable 2025 period (APP 2026). More than 500 KP police have been killed since 2023. The 18 September 2026 Kohat Police Lines attack killed at least 31 people, most of them officers at Friday prayers, and the 2 August 2026 bombing of a police station in Swat's Kabal region — killing 17 — signalled the insurgency's return to a district that had been the showcase of post-2009 recovery. Civilians remain the second-largest fatality category in the province.

3. The conflict has become regional

The October 2025 border clashes, the Qatari-mediated Doha ceasefire and the November 2025 Istanbul monitoring mechanism failed to hold; on 26 February 2026 Pakistan launched Operation Ghazab-lil-Haq, described by its defence minister as "open war." Reciprocal strikes and artillery exchanges continued through October 2026. UNAMA recorded 1,100-plus Afghan civilian casualties in 2026 by late September (Khaama 2026). Two Eid ceasefires collapsed. Mediation by Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Türkiye and China stabilised the front episodically but produced no verified agreement. Combatant casualty claims by both sides are contested and are reported as claims.

4. What has worked has not persisted

The 2009 Swat campaign (Rah-e-Rast) and the 2014–2017 Zarb-e-Azb/National Action Plan period achieved genuine suppression, and the province's recovery — rebuilt bazaars, 12.4 million tourists in 2025 — proves normalization is possible. But suppression was not converted into settlement, and the seven-criteria assessment of military operations in the monograph

shows the same decay sequence in every case: clearance, decline, complacency, militant regeneration, recurrence. Regeneration has been fastest where a sanctuary existed — the situation since 2021.

5. The FATA merger is constitutionally successful and fiscally failing

The 25th Amendment (2018) ended a century of legal exception; the implementation did not follow the constitution. Against a commitment of 3 per cent of the divisible pool (roughly Rs 700 billion over the first award period), only Rs 132 billion had reached the merged districts by mid-2026 — a Rs 568 billion shortfall — while the commitment expires in 2028 (The News 2026). The merged districts lack functioning courts, elected local government, and the police capacity promised at merger; the result is a security vacuum that the TTP fills and a grievance narrative that Islamabad's promises cannot answer.

6. Five structural drivers explain persistence

(i) **Sanctuary economics** — Afghanistan provides rear bases, recruits and weapons; (ii) **institutional bifurcation** — the military leads counter-insurgency while provincially funded, locally recruited police absorb the casualties, producing intelligence gaps and blame-shifting (ICG 2026); (iii) **a justice vacuum** — courts are shallow in the merged districts, impunity is pervasive, and communities experience the state as coercion without adjudication; (iv) **the war economy** — extortion, taxation, mining and smuggling create constituencies for disorder; and (v) **ideological reproduction** — madrasa and online radicalization pipelines generate recruits faster than unevaluated rehabilitation programmes can absorb them.

7. Scenarios to 2035

Three futures are assessed in the monograph: **Sustained Normalization** (15–20 per cent) — requiring a verified cross-border arrangement, the fiscal settlement, and a police–justice build-out; **Fragile Equilibrium** (50–60 per cent) — the continuation of current trends: 1,400–2,500 fatalities a year, recurrent displacement, and institutional stagnation; and **Deterioration** (25–30 per cent) — interstate escalation, urban mass-casualty terrorism, and the erosion of state control in parts of the south. The decisive variables are fiscal delivery, police protection, and political inclusion — all within Pakistan's control.

8. The strategic recommendation

Move from a counter-terrorism campaign to a **state-building compact**, organized around six commitments:

#	Commitment	Why it is the binding constraint
1	Pay the money — legislate the merged-district transfer and clear the Rs 568 bn arrears	The merger's credibility and the districts' reconstruction depend on it
2	Protect the police — protected mobility, counter-IED/counter-drone, insurance and compensation	It is the force that is dying; recruitment and reform fail without it
3	Staff the courts — judicial presence in the merged districts and ATC throughput targets	Impunity sustains both militancy and grievance
4	Elect the councils — local government in the merged districts with devolved budgets	The missing tier of the security architecture
5	Restore lawful politics — lift the PTM proscription, release those without terrorism charges, protect journalists	Exclusion is the recruitment channel; criminalising dissent is counter-insurgency self-harm
6	Verify what is done — a published annual Normalization Report with an independent panel	Accountability converts promises into outcomes

9. Financing: the investment case

The monograph estimates KP's annual conflict-related economic loss at **Rs 400–800 billion**. The roadmap's incremental requirement — roughly **Rs 150–250 billion per year at maturity** plus the Rs 568 billion arrears — is therefore **one-quarter to one-half of what insecurity already costs**. Normalization is not a humanitarian expense; it is the highest-return investment available to the federation, and it is financed largely by reallocation and political will, not by new external dependency.

10. What success looks like

By 2035: conflict fatalities below 400 a year; no district under sustained TTP taxation or parallel courts; police losses below 50 a year; 75 per cent of anti-terrorism cases concluded within 24 months; the merged-district transfer delivered and audited annually; elected councils across the seven districts; merged-district poverty within ten points of the provincial average; and no proscription of non-violent political parties. These are measurable, verifiable, and — the monograph argues — achievable on a fifteen-year horizon. The alternative is a decade more of the present: episodic campaigns, cumulative displacement, a

police force bled white, and a missed generation.

The choice does not rest with the Taliban, the TTP, or any external actor. The binding constraints are domestic: the willingness to fund, to protect, to adjudicate, to include, and to be measured.